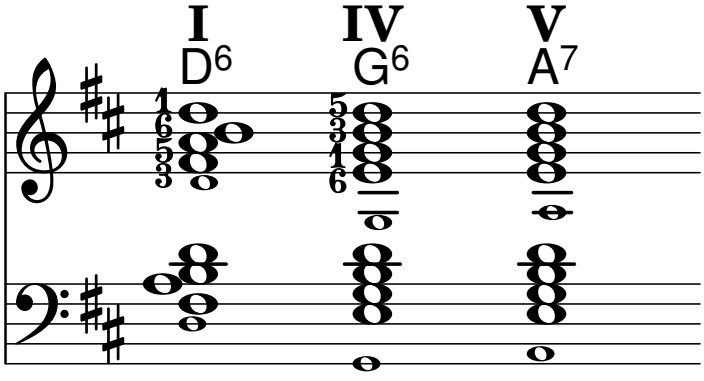
Blues Background Formula

Harmonizing improvised backgrounds over a 12-bar blues in concert D

How it works: one person makes up a background rhythm on the tonic; everyone repeats it.
Next time around each player picks *any* one note out of the formula and moves it with the chords of the blues.
I^{6} = 3 5 6 1 · **IV**^{6} = 6 1 3 5 · **V**^{7} = the same four notes as IV (5 ♭7 9 11 over the V root).
The small bottom note of each stack is the root — tuba/sousaphone. Horns choose from the four numbered notes above it.

C (written in D)

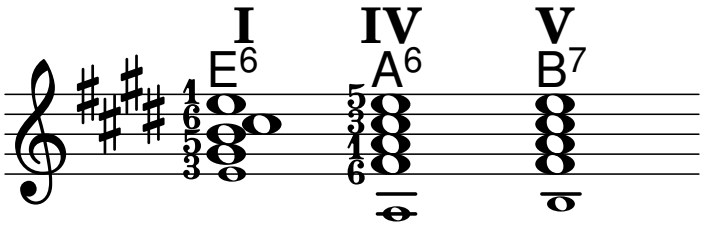
flute · bells · trombone · sousaphone — bass clef reads the lower staff



D^{6}	D^{6}	D^{6}	D^{6}
G^{6}	G^{6}	D^{6}	D^{6}
A^{7}	G^{6}	D^{6}	D^{6}

B♭ (written in E)

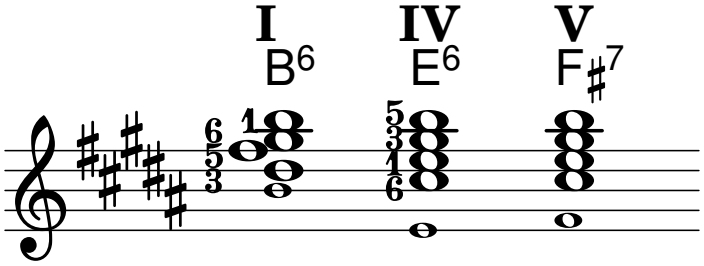
trumpet · clarinet · soprano & tenor sax · baritone · bass sax



E^{6}	E^{6}	E^{6}	E^{6}
A^{6}	A^{6}	E^{6}	E^{6}
B^{7}	A^{6}	E^{6}	E^{6}

E♭ (written in B)

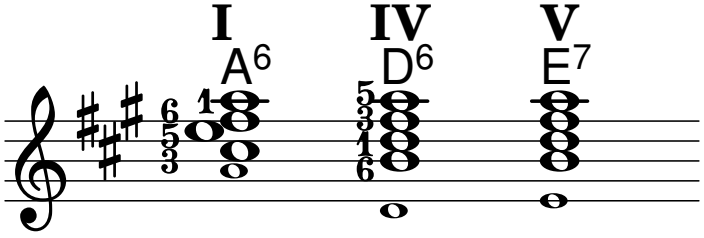
alto sax · bari sax



B^{6}	B^{6}	B^{6}	B^{6}
E^{6}	E^{6}	B^{6}	B^{6}
F♯^{7}	E^{6}	B^{6}	B^{6}

F (written in A)

french horn



A^{6}	A^{6}	A^{6}	A^{6}
D^{6}	D^{6}	A^{6}	A^{6}
E^{7}	D^{6}	A^{6}	A^{6}